

PTI

ALL FOR A DROP People filling up water from a tanker in Bhagirathpura, Indore, Jan. 5

outpost was contaminating the water.

The official death toll of 16 is widely believed to reflect less than half the actual figure. Thousands are said to have been affected; 437 were hospitalised at over 40 locations; nearly three times more exhibited symptoms but got treated at home. Lab tests of the water confirmed a deadly "polymicrobial" cocktail: *E. coli*, Salmonella and *Vibrio cholera*. In vulnerable patients, it led to sepsis, kidney failure, liver abscess.

THE FALL OF INDORE

So, how did Indore go from poster-boy status to this dismal nadir? Residents blame the administration's "cosmetic approach", where it lost sight of basics. Narrow-laned Bhagirathpura—an unplanned *mohalla* that came up in the 1980s, largely housing migrant labour—was almost set up to be a tragic case study. Its sewage network was laid in the 1990s; the water line later in the decade; Narmada water supply began in early 2000s. Complaints about damaged pipelines were being made since 2024. The unpardonable bit: the city fathers *knew* it was needed. But as always, it waited as administrative apathy got married to political wrangling.

It was decreed in 2021 that a part of the locality's pipelines be replaced; a Rs 2.66 crore project using HDPE pipes was approved. It took two years, till February 2023, for work to be allocated. The longest delay, of five months, was at the mayor's office. Only three-fourths of the work has been completed. November 2024 begot a Rs 3.26 crore project to change the remaining pipelines (later shorn to Rs 2.83 crore). The tender was called, but the process sped up only after the deaths began to be reported.

Takeaways

- **HC rules out govt. probe, single-judge inquiry panel solicits evidence from public**
- **Interim report set for March, but larger questions relate to Indore's complex politics**

The internal politics of the ruling BJP, many suggest, has a bearing on how Indore is run. As the commercial capital of MP, the city is coveted all around: politicians want to control it, official postings are reserved for the brightest of favourites. CM Mohan Yadav, the district minister-in-charge, has had a chequered history with Kailash Vijayvargiya, state urban administration minister and MLA from Indore 1, in which Bhagirathpura falls.

Controlling Vijayvargiya's writ, via bureaucratic vigil, has apparently been the strategy for all CMs. It's not easy. Indore mayor Pushyamitra Bhargava, a Vijayvargiya loyalist, was said to be not getting along too well with IMC commissioner Dilip Yadav, who was transferred out after the incident. In fact, Bhargava has seen multiple commissioners during his tenure.

Says Kishore Kodwani, founder of the NGO that filed one of the PILs that has now led to the judicial commission: "Even the cleanliness awards are not above board. Why are there mountains of waste where fires keep happening? Indore is the proverbial one-eyed king in a sea of the blind." ■